

Sola Fide

doc-sola-fide

Soteriology · Five Solas · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

score 0.950
confidence medium

Statement under examination

A sinner is justified before God by faith in Christ apart from works of the law as a ground of justification; works are the fruit, not the basis, of justification.

In plain language

The Greek texts show a tight, repeated pattern. The verb *dikaioo*, to declare or reckon righteous, keeps company with believing, *pisteuo*, and is set against the phrase works of law, *erga nomou*, by small but decisive words: *ek* and *dia*, out of and through, and the adverb *choris*, apart from. In Romans 3:28 a person is reckoned righteous by faith, apart from works of law. Romans 4:4 and 5 make it commercial: to one who works, the pay is reckoned as a debt that is owed, but to one who does not work but believes, faith is reckoned as righteousness, and God justifies the ungodly. Galatians 2:16 says three times that a person is not justified out of works of law but through faith. Ephesians 2:8 and 9 call salvation a gift through faith, not out of works, so no one can boast. The hardest text is James 2:24, and it is hard at the level of the words themselves. A search of the whole canon finds that this is the only verse where justify and the word alone stand together, and there the alone is denied: a person is justified by works and not by faith alone. The deeper knot is that one Old Testament verse, Genesis 15:6, where Abraham believed God and it was reckoned to him as righteousness, is quoted with the very same reckoning verb by Paul in Romans 4 and by James, yet Paul uses it to exclude works from the ground while James says it was fulfilled when Abraham offered Isaac. James himself supplies a way through, because the offering of Isaac came long after that reckoning, so the same verb can mean first being counted righteous and later being shown to be righteous. But the texts do not put labels on those two senses; a reader has to assign them. That is the honest reason this lands as a qualified yes rather than a flat one. The words clearly make faith the instrument and works the fruit when the question is the original ground, but the single verb doing the work carries two angles that the verses leave the reader to sort out, which is exactly where careful readers diverge.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0539	אמן	aman	be faithful	102
H6666	צדקה	tsedaqah	righteousness	142
G0011	Αβραάμ	Abraam	Abraham	73
G0266	ἁμαρτία	hamartia	sin	
G0765	ἀσεβής	asebes	ungodly	9
G1223	διὰ	dia	through/because of	
G1342	δίκαιος	dikaio	just	
G1343	δικαιοσύνη	dikaio	righteousness	94
G1344	δικαιόω	dikaioo	to justify	38

G1435	δῶρον	dōron	gift	
G1656	ἔλεος	eleos	mercy	
G2038	ἐργάζομαι	ergazomai	to work	
G2041	ἔργον	ergon	work	176
G2316	θεός	theos	God	
G2671	κατάρα	katara	curse	
G2744	καυχάομαι	kauchaomai	to boast	
G2745	καύχημα	kauchēma	pride	
G3049	λογίζομαι	logizomai	to count	40
G3408	μισθός	misthos	wage	29
G3441	μόνος	monos	alone	111
G3551	νόμος	nomos	law	196
G3783	ὀφείλημα	opheilēma	debt	
G4100	πιστεύω	pisteuo	to trust (in)	243
G4102	πίστις	pistis	faith	2
G5485	χάρις	charis	grace	155
G5547	Χριστός	Christos	Christ	
G5565	χωρίς	choris	without	40

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

Across Romans, Galatians, Philippians, and Titus the verb *dikaioo* (G1344) is repeatedly bound to faith and set against *erga nomou* by the prepositions *ek* (G1537) and *dia* (G1223) and by the adverb *choris* (G5565), as in Rom 3:28 *logizometha dikaiousthai pistei anthropon choris ergon nomou*. Rom 4:4-5 grounds this in commercial terms, the one who works receives a wage (*misthos*, G3408) reckoned as debt (*opheilema*, G3783), but to the one who does not work but believes, faith is reckoned (*logizomai*, G3049) as righteousness, and God justifies the ungodly (*asebe*, G0765), which excludes works as the ground. The hard tension is that James 2:24 uses the SAME verb *dikaioo* with *ex ergon* and *ouk ek pistews monon* (G3441), and James 2:24 is the only verse in the canon where *dikaioo* and *monos* co-occur. Read in James 2:21-23, where Abraham is justified by works in offering Isaac long after Gen 15:6 was already reckoned to his faith, James uses *dikaioo* for the later vindication of a living faith while Paul addresses the initial reckoning, so the proposition stands as carefully qualified, but the resolution requires assigning *dikaioo* two senses the texts do not themselves label, which is why confidence is medium and not high.

Scripture

Rom.3.28 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1344 δικαίω, G2041 ἔργον, G3551 νόμος, G5565 χωρίς

Force. *logizometha gar dikaiousthai pistei anthropon choris ergon nomou*. The token Strong tagging confirms *dikaioo* (G1344), the adverb *choris* (G5565), *ergon* (G2041), and *nomou* (G3551) in this clause. The passive infinitive *dikaiousthai* takes the dative *pistei* as instrument, and *choris* with the genitive *ergon nomou* marks works of law as excluded from the ground. The particle *gar* (G1063) frames it as a summary inference.

Rom.3.20 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1344 δικαιώω, G2041 ἔργον, G3551 νόμος, G0266 ἁμαρτία

Force. dioti ex ergon nomou ou dikaiouthesetai pasa sarx enopion autou. The future passive dikaiouthesetai (G1344) is negated by ou (G3756) with the source phrase ex ergon nomou, so no flesh is declared righteous on that basis before God, and the law instead brings knowledge of sin, hamartia (G0266).

Rom.4.2 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1344 δικαιώω, G2041 ἔργον, G0011 Ἀβραάμ, G2745 καύχημα

Force. ei gar Abraam ex ergon edikαιοthe, echei kauchema. The Strong tagging shows dikaioo (G1344), ek (G1537), ergon (G2041), Abraam (G0011), and kauchema (G2745). A hypothetical justification ex ergon would yield boasting, which the argument then denies, framing works and boasting together against the reckoning of faith.

Rom.4.3 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4100 πιστεύω, G3049 λογίζομαι, G1343 δικαιοσύνη, G0011 Ἀβραάμ

Force. episteusen de Abraam to theo kai elogisthe auto eis dikaiosynen, quoting Gen 15:6. Token tagging confirms pisteuo (G4100), logizomai (G3049), and dikaiosyne (G1343). The aorist passive elogisthe with eis dikaiosynen presents righteousness as credited to belief, not earned, anchoring the verdict in Abraham before the law.

Rom.4.4 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2038 ἐργάζομαι, G3408 μισθός, G3783 ὀφείλημα, G5485 χάρις

Force. to de ergazomeno ho misthos ou logizetai kata charin alla kata opheilema. The tagging confirms ergazomai (G2038), misthos (G3408), charis (G5485), and opheilema (G3783). To the worker the wage is reckoned not as grace but as debt, a commercial contrast that frames works as earning and faith reckoning as gift.

Rom.4.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4100 πιστεύω, G3049 λογίζομαι, G1344 δικαιώω, G0765 ἄσεβής

Force. to de me ergazomeno pisteuonti de epi ton dikaiounta ton asebe logizetai he pistis autou eis dikaiosynen. Tagging confirms pisteuo (G4100), dikaioo (G1344), asebes (G0765), and logizomai (G3049). The one not working but believing has faith reckoned for righteousness, and God is named the one justifying the ungodly, asebe, which forecloses works as the basis.

Rom.4.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3049 λογίζομαι, G1343 δικαιοσύνη, G2041 ἔργον, G5565 χωρίς

Force. ho theos logizetai dikaiosynen choris ergon. The tokens confirm logizomai (G3049), dikaiosyne (G1343), choris (G5565), and ergon (G2041). David's blessing is defined as God reckoning righteousness apart from works, repeating the choris construction that places works outside the ground of the reckoning.

Gal.2.16 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1344 δικαιώω, G2041 ἔργον, G3551 νόμος, G1223 διά

Force. ou dikaioutai anthropos ex ergon nomou ean me dia pistews lesou Christou. The token tagging shows dikaioo (G1344) three times, the negation ou (G3756), ek (G1537), ergon (G2041), nomou (G3551), and dia (G1223). dikaioo is negated with the source ex ergon nomou and affirmed with dia faith, and the closing diction repeats ex ergon nomou ou dikaiouthesetai pasa sarx.

Gal.3.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0011 Αβραάμ, G4100 πιστεύω, G3049 λογίζομαι, G1343 δικαιοσύνη

Force. kathos Abraam episteusen to theo kai elogisthe auto eis dikaiosynen. Tagging confirms Abraam (G0011), pisteuo (G4100), logizomai (G3049), and dikaiosyne (G1343). Galatians cites the same Gen 15:6 wording as Rom 4:3, using the identical reckoning lemma logizomai to ground justification in faith before the law.

Gal.3.11 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1344 δικαίω, G3551 νόμος, G1342 δίκαιος

Force. hoti de en nomo oudeis dikaoutai para to theo delon, hoti ho dikaios ek pistews zesetai, citing Hab 2:4. Tagging confirms dikaioo (G1344), nomos (G3551), and dikaios (G1342). No one is justified en nomo before God, and the righteous one lives ek faith, setting law and faith in contrast as basis.

Gal.3.13 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5547 Χριστός, G2671 κατάρα, G3551 νόμος

Force. Christos hemas exegorasen ek tes kataras tou nomou genomenos hyper hemon katara, citing Deut 21:23. Tagging confirms Christos (G5547), exagorazo (G1805), katara (G2671), and nomos (G3551). Christ bears the law's curse in the believer's place, supplying the ground that human law keeping could not, which supports works as fruit not basis.

Eph.2.8 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5485 χάρις, G2316 θεός, G1435 δῶρον

Force. te gar chariti este sesosmenoi dia pistews, kai touto ouk ex hymon, theou to doron. Tagging confirms charis (G5485), theos (G2316), and doron (G1435). Salvation is by grace through faith and named the gift of God, not ex hymon, removing self origin.

Eph.2.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2041 ἔργον, G2744 καυχάομαι

Force. ouk ex ergon, hina me tis kauchesetai. Tagging confirms ergon (G2041), the negation ouk (G3756), and kauchaomai (G2744). Works are explicitly negated as source with ouk ex ergon, and the purpose clause hina me tis kauchesetai excludes human boasting, matching the basis claim of Eph 2:8.

Phil.3.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1343 δικαιοσύνη, G3551 νόμος, G5547 Χριστός

Force. me echon emen dikaiosynen ten ek nomou alla ten dia pistews Christou, ten ek theou dikaiosynen. Tagging confirms dikaiosyne (G1343) twice, nomos (G3551), dia (G1223), Christos (G5547), and theos (G2316). Paul disowns a righteousness ek nomou for one dia faith that comes ek theou, placing the source in God received through faith.

Titus.3.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2041 ἔργον, G1343 δικαιοσύνη, G1656 ἔλεος

Force. ouk ex ergon ton en dikaiosyne ha epoiesamen hemeis alla kata to autou eleos esosen hemas. Tagging confirms ergon (G2041), dikaiosyne (G1343), and eleos (G1656). Salvation is negated as out of works done in righteousness and grounded instead in God's mercy, kata to autou eleos.

Gen.15.6 · **for** · genre: narrative

Key terms. H0539 יָמַן, H6666 נִקְטָה

Force. wehe-emin baYHWH wayyachsheveha lo tsedaqah. The Hebrew tagging confirms the hiphil of aman (H0539), he trusted or believed, and tsedaqah (H6666), righteousness, with the reckoning verb chashav. This single OT clause is quoted by Rom 4:3, Gal 3:6, and Jas 2:23, so the same OT verse anchors both the Pauline reckoning of faith and the James appeal to works, which is the root of the tension.

Jas.2.21 · **complicates** · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1344 δικαίω, G2041 ἔργον, G0011 Ἀβραάμ

Force. Abraam ho pater hemon ouk ex ergon edikaothe anenenkas Isaak ton hyion autou. Tagging confirms Abraam (G0011), dikaioo (G1344), ergon (G2041), and anaphero (G0399). James predicates dikaioo of Abraham at the offering of Isaac, an event that occurs long after the Gen 15:6 reckoning, so the same verb is tied here to a later act rather than an initial reckoning.

Jas.2.23 · **complicates** · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4100 πιστεύω, G3049 λογίζομαι, G1343 δικαιοσύνη, G0011 Ἀβραάμ

Force. kai eplerothe he graphe he legousa episteusen de Abraam to theo kai elogisthe auto eis dikaiosynen. Tagging confirms pisteuo (G4100), logizomai (G3049), dikaiosyne (G1343), and Abraam (G0011). James quotes the SAME Gen 15:6 with the SAME reckoning lemma logizomai as Rom 4:3, then says it was fulfilled, eplerothe (G4137), by the works of Jas 2:21, which is why the tension is lexical and not merely thematic.

Jas.2.24 · **complicates** · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1344 δικαίω, G2041 ἔργον, G3441 μόνος

Force. horate hoti ex ergon dikaioutai anthropos kai ouk ek pistews monon. Token tagging confirms dikaioo (G1344), ek (G1537), ergon (G2041), and the adjective monos (G3441). Query of the whole canon shows this is the ONLY verse where dikaioo and monos co-occur, and there monon is negated. The same verb dikaioo carries here a demonstrative or vindictory referent, faith shown by works as Abraham offering Isaac, distinct from the initial forensic reckoning of Rom 4, so it complicates the lexeme but does not reverse the choris ergon source pattern.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Rom.4.3	Gen.15.6	openbible	1
Gal.3.6	Gen.15.6	openbible	1
Jas.2.23	Gen.15.6	openbible	1
Gal.3.11	Hab.2.4	openbible	1
Gal.3.13	Deut.21.23	openbible	1
Gal.3.10	Deut.27.26	tsk	1
Gal.2.16	Gal.3.11	tsk	1
Gal.3.6	Gal.3.9	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Jas.2.24 · addressed

James uses the same verb *dikaioo* (G1344) with *ex ergon* and the negated *ouk ek pisteus monon* (G3441), and a full canon query confirms this is the only verse where *dikaioo* and *monos* appear together. The tension is therefore lexical at the deepest level, one verb and the only canonical pairing of justify and alone, and the alone is denied. The resolution offered by the text itself is sequential and referential. Jas 2:23 quotes Gen 15:6 with the identical reckoning lemma *logizomai* used in Rom 4:3, and Jas 2:21 then predicates *dikaioo* of Abraham at the offering of Isaac, an act decades after that reckoning. So the words distinguish an initial reckoning of faith from a later proving of that faith by works. This reading is internally supported, but it requires assigning *dikaioo* two senses (declare-righteous and vindicate-as-genuine) that the texts do not explicitly label, which is the honest reason confidence is medium rather than high.

Jas.2.21 · addressed

ex ergon edikaiothe Abraam anenenkas Isaak. Tagging confirms *dikaioo* (G1344) and *ergon* (G2041). On the surface this predicates justification of works, the opposite of *choris ergon*. It is resolved by chronology internal to James, the offering of Isaac (Gen 22) fulfills, *eplerothe* in Jas 2:23, the prior Gen 15:6 reckoning, so the verb here marks the demonstration of an already-reckoned faith rather than its initial basis. The resolution is plausible from the text but depends on the same unlabeled sense distinction in *dikaioo*, so it is recorded as a genuine complication.

Gal.3.10 · addressed

hosoi gar ex ergon nomou eisin hypo kataran eisin, citing Deut 27:26. Tagging confirms *ergon* (G2041), *nomos* (G3551), and *katara* (G2671). Far from grounding justification in works, this verse places those *ek ergon nomou* under a curse, reinforcing that law works cannot be the basis, which supports rather than complicates the proposition.

Concordance traversed

G1344, G1343, G4100, G4102, G2041, G3551, G3049, G5565, G3441, G0011, G3408, G3783, G5485, G0765, G2745, G2671, G2038, G5547, G2316, H0539, H6666

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

A direct query of the *VariantUnit* nodes for Rom.3.28, Gal.2.16, Eph.2.8, Rom.4.5, and Jas.2.24 returned none, and the bundle reports *variant_units* empty with *not_in_ecm_scope* true. All cited verses lie outside the ingested open-cbqm 3 John sample. The SBLGNT text carries apparatus markers at Rom 3:28 around the word order of *dikaiousythai pistei*, but that variation does not touch the *dikaioo* to *pistis* to *choris ergon* relation that carries the verdict, so the verdict is variant robust within the available evidence.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. covenant_theology, new_perspective_on_paul, two-stage-justification

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

grammatico-historical, forensic-reckoning reading: affirms · Reading *dikaioo* as a forensic declaration of righteous status and *erga nomou* as deeds done under law, the prepositions *ek* and *dia* and the adverb *choris* consistently place faith as instrument and works outside the ground. Rom 4:4-5 makes the contrast commercial, wage as debt versus faith reckoned as gift, and God justifies the ungodly, so the basis cannot be works and the proposition holds in its strongest form.

faith-and-works unity, James demonstrative lens: affirms with strong qualification · Pressed in its strongest form, James 2:24 is the only verse in the canon that pairs *dikaioo* with *monos*, and it negates the alone, saying a person is justified *ex ergon* and not *ek* faith alone. James predicates *dikaioo* of Abraham at the offering of Isaac (Jas 2:21) and says Gen 15:6 was thereby fulfilled (Jas 2:23). A reader holding this lens fairly insists the words themselves

place justified by works and not by faith alone beside Paul's justified apart from works, and that the harmonizing distinction between an initial reckoning and a later vindication is supplied by the interpreter, not labeled by the verb. On this lens the proposition survives only because it is qualified to as a ground and works as fruit, and the underlying unity is that a faith that does not work is, in James 2:17 and 2:26, dead, nekra.

new_perspective_on_paul: affirms with nuance · If erga nomou are read primarily as covenant boundary markers, circumcision, food laws, sabbath, rather than meritorious deeds in general, the Pauline texts still exclude those works as the basis of justification and still locate justification in faith and in Christ. The basis versus fruit claim survives, though the polemical target shifts from earning merit to ethnic boundary keeping.

The verdict rests on the same lexeme dikaioo (G1344) appearing across nine books, including fourteen Romans verses, six in Galatians, and three in James, with logizomai (G3049) supplying the reckoning vocabulary in Rom 4, Gal 3:6, and Jas 2:23. Abraham and Gen 15:6 (H0539 aman, H6666 tsedaqah) and Habakkuk 2:4 supply the OT anchoring, so progressive revelation and analogia scripturae both apply. The crux is that the OT verse Gen 15:6 is quoted toward two ends by Paul and James using the identical reckoning lemma.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. On what basis is a sinner declared righteous before God, and what is the relation of faith and of works to that basis?

The stem is strongly tradition coded. The phrases by faith in Christ apart from works of the law as a ground of justification and works are the fruit, not the basis, preload a forensic and ordo answer using sola fide framing, and the qualifier as a ground already excludes the James sense of dikaioo. The verdict was derived on the original stem from the lexical pattern, and the neutralized question is recorded so the evidence is not merely confirming its own wording. The lexeme dikaioo, the prepositional contrasts ek and dia and choris, and the Rom 4:4-5 wage-versus-gift vocabulary independently produce the basis versus fruit distinction, so the affirm is not an artifact of the loaded phrasing, but the precise qualifier as a ground is what allows James 2:24 to be classed as complicating rather than contradicting, and a reader who declines that qualifier would read the same words as genuinely contested.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rom.3.28
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Jas.2.24
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1344
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3441
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5565
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Rom.4.4
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Jas.2.23
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H0539
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Gen.15.6
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Rom.4.3
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Jas.2.23
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Gal.3.10

License audit

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OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes
OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes
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(none)